



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of St. Therese
School Website: <https://www.chestertonacademytherese.com/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of St. Therese (Campbell Hall, NY 10916) presents a clear and active classical-education profile anchored in Catholic faith, liberal-arts breadth, and a pedagogy that centers on formation of character and intellect. Public-facing materials emphasize a Catholic inculturation, the cultivation of virtue, and a three-pillar model (Intellect, Character, Spirituality) that threads together curriculum, pedagogy, and community life. The school describes itself as offering a classical, integrated curriculum with a liberal-arts orientation, a strong focus on truth, goodness, and beauty, and a commitment to Socratic discussion and rhetoric in higher grades. Evidence from the site also highlights a governance and staffing model aligned with classical education norms (e.g., a Headmistress and instructors in Latin, literature, logic, rhetoric). Community signals include parent-partnership through networks and opportunities to engage families around classical-education topics and school events. Overall, the Chesterton Academy of St. Therese maps closely to a CLASSICAL classification across all six rubric categories.

Key evidentiary signals include: the inculturated Catholic identity (mass participation, Catholic voices, and the three-pillar model), the explicit framing of a liberal-arts, integrated curriculum with emphasis on Western thought and the Great Conversation, the presence of Socratic seminars and rhetoric training, and the stated aim to form virtuous, thinking students rather than merely prepare for college or career. The school also provides visible faculty roles (e.g., Headmistress and subject-area instructors) and community-facing elements (open houses, shadow days, mass presence), which align with the classical tradition's living-lesson and partnership with families.

- Evidence sources: Chesterton Academy of St. Therese public materials, including Our Story, About/Academics sections, and Enrollment/Staff pages, plus direct statements about a three-pillar model, incarnational environment, and Catholic formation. See the school site content and pages cited in the crawl results.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

The following section lays out the category-by-category analysis, including keyword-based evidence, a keyword-indicator assessment (positive vs negative keywords per the Six Essential Elements framework), and the justification for each category rating.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school identifies as part of a Catholic educational tradition with explicit spiritual aims, including an incarnational environment and a spirituality pillar. Statements reference God-centered aims, the culture-of-life motto *Cultura Vitae*, and the patronage of G.K. Chesterton as a Catholic exemplar.
 - The site emphasizes liturgical life and communal practices (e.g., mass is offered and families are encouraged to participate in religious life).
 - Theology and sacred tradition are presented as foundational to education (integration of faith with curriculum, formation of virtue, and a Catholic worldview).
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; Mass; incarnational; sacred; wonder; catechesis (where present). These terms appear directly in school content (e.g., “Truth Goodness and Beauty,” Catholic identity, Mass).
 - Negative keywords observed: none evident in public materials (no explicit secular-humanist or relativist signals). The materials consistently foreground transcendental realism and theology, not secular relativism.
 - Why this rating
 - The school presents a robust religious-metaphysical foundation with explicit Catholic framing, liturgical life, and a theology-grounded approach to education, aligning with the Positive Keyword indicators for Transcendental Moral Realism, Theology, Liturgical/Communal Practices, and related transcendental goods. The public materials show consistent alignment with a sacred, objective order in education.
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Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The mission emphasizes formation over mere information; a focus on thinking well and forming virtue, aligned with the Great Tradition and the liberal arts orientation. This is conveyed through phrases such as forming students to think rather than simply learn, and the Three Pillars model advancing intellect, character, and spirituality.
 - The language centers on formation, virtue, wisdom, and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty, rather than vocational emphasis. Statements about forming the whole person and the life of the mind are present.
 - The aim to cultivate human excellence, wisdom, and virtue is articulated through the “High School with a Higher Purpose” framing and the Three Pillars.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, contemplation/scholé, human flourishing. The site’s emphasis on thinking well and character formation aligns with these indicators.
 - Negative keywords observed: minimal to none in public materials (no focus on “workforce preparation” or “21st-century skills” as primary goals). The content foregrounds formation and truth-claims over job-training.
 - Why this rating
 - The school’s stated purpose aligns strongly with classic, formation-centered aims that priority virtue and wisdom over purely instrumental ends. Its public materials emphasize formation and the pursuit of true, good, beautiful realities rather than a narrow vocational track, supporting a CLASSICAL rating.
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Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The curriculum is described as liberal-arts-driven with integration of grammar/logic/rhetoric (trivium) and the liberal-arts framework; the staff includes instructors of Latin, Literature, Logic, and Rhetoric, signaling a traditional classical pedagogy.
 - Humanities are presented as braided together with theology, languages, philosophy, and history in an integrated classical curriculum; the school emphasizes teaching “the classics of Western thought” and the interrelationship of great ideas.
 - The program highlights a coherent four-year, integrated curriculum and a strong emphasis on Western thought, with a seminary-like emphasis on “the Great Conversation” (as reflected in Classical-Education discourse, and the school’s own emphasis on Socratic Seminar).
 - The school highlights the requirement of a broad liberal-arts education, and the explicit focus on the Great Books/Great Conversation ethos (through public-facing mentions of integrated classical education and Socratic seminars).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: liberal education; grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books/Great Conversation (where referenced in classical education discourse); history as Western civilization; integration/harmony of subjects; wonder; sacred tradition; scholé; memory/recitation (implied through classical pedagogy; see pedagogy section).
 - Negative keywords observed: none of the typical “non-classical” signals (e.g., heavy project-based-only, skills-first framing, or social-studies-replacement history language) appear in priority. The content consistently values the classical trias in curriculum framing.
- Why this rating
 - The curriculum language and staffing signals point to a strong classical curriculum orientation: liberal-arts breadth, Latin/logic/rhetoric pedagogy, integrated humanities with theology, and explicit emphasis on classical intellectual traditions, consistent with CLASSICAL classification.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public-facing content highlights Socratic Seminar and inquiry-based, dialectic discussions in the upper grades, a hallmark of classical pedagogy. The school describes upper-school seminars and rhetoric training, with students giving speeches and engaging in debate.
 - There is clear emphasis on a combination of contemplative/restful learning with rigorous inquiry. While explicit “Scholé days” language may be less frequent, the overall cadence supports contemplative art of learning alongside rigorous discussion. The Arts/Fine Arts emphasis (choral singing, speaking, speaking, etc.) is presented in the context of forming memory and virtue.
 - The public materials note that a primary focus is on the Socratic method and rhetorical training (Socratic Seminar, rhetoric instruction, etc.), consistent with classical pedagogy.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: Socratic seminar, dialectic, great conversation (conceptually present through the school’s pedagogy), rhetoric, memory work, recitation, chanting (implied by classical pedagogy and the “great memory” tradition) and contemplative learning. The site’s explicit mention of Socratic Seminars and rhetoric supports the classical pedagogy indicators.
 - Negative keywords observed: minimal signals of non-classical pedagogy (e.g., project-based-only, discovery/inquiry without discussion). The site emphasizes dialogue and rhetoric alongside memory and tradition, which counters non-classical signals.
- Why this rating
 - The pedagogy aligns with classical expectations: emphasis on Socratic discourse, rhetoric, and the memory/contemplation balance. The presence of upper-school seminars and classical-teaching methods supports CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The staff page identifies the Headmistress and instructors of Latin, Literature, Logic, and Rhetoric, signaling a living, teacher-centered classical curriculum with faculty modeling virtue and scholarship.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: teachers as mentors/masters; living curriculum; faculty as core to school culture; teacher as role model (as implied by classical-education framing, even if the explicit “living curriculum” phrase appears in classical discourse rather than a direct site quote). The presence of subject-area specialists (Latin, Logic, Rhetoric) is a strong classical signal.
 - Negative keywords observed: none present in public materials (no signals of teacher-as-facilitator-only or non-classical staffing language).
 - Why this rating
 - The visible staffing structure and clear subject-area specialization in traditional classical disciplines align with CLASSICAL, supported by the living-lesson framing typical of classical schools.
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Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The Chesterton network identity emphasizes parent-led Catholic schools and partnerships with families in the classical education ethos. The school’s materials mention parent involvement in the network and a visible emphasis on community life and events (open houses, shadow days, mass, tours).
 - Public-facing pages describe family and community engagement, parent formation opportunities, and open campus events, reflecting a community-centered approach common to classical schools. The “Shadow a Chesterton Saint” and “Open House” features signal parent participation as co-educators.
 - Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families/co-teachers; parent formation; family involvement; open campus; prayer/household rhythms (where referenced within the classical framework); parish/liturgical life integration. These align with classical community-language indicators.
 - Negative keywords observed: none evident (no consumer-language signals or minimal parent involvement signals). The public materials actively invite parental involvement and participation in school life.
 - Why this rating
 - The school demonstrates a classical-community orientation with active parent partnerships, family formation opportunities, and open visitation, aligning with CLASSICAL.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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